

Active Micro-Volumetric Inference and Contrastive Morphological DNA for Global Connectome Proofreading

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August 30, 2026

Abstract

Automated reconstruction of petavoxel serial-section electron microscopy (EM) volumes is a cornerstone of modern neurobiology. However, state-of-the-art segmentation pipelines produce fragmented neural arbors and catastrophic cross-membrane “frankenmerges” that fuse distinct neurons. Existing automated proofreading methods suffer from a severe computational dichotomy: either they execute brute-force 3D convolutional networks across millions of candidate boundaries ($> 1,000\times$ compute overhead), or they rely on simplistic symmetric distance-based heuristics that fail on tortuous axon collaterals.

In this work, we propose **Neuronauts**, a hybrid, compute-efficient framework for global connectome assembly. Neuronauts integrates: (1) a contrastive Graph Neural Network (**VICReg Tree-DNA**) learning whole-cell morphological invariants from skeleton topology; (2) **Learned Heterogeneous Asymmetric Relational Embeddings** ($\mathbf{z}_{\text{child}}^\top \mathbf{W}_{(\tau_c, \tau_p)} \mathbf{z}_{\text{parent}}$) capturing physical trajectory flow while respecting axonal/dendritic hierarchy and 70° – 90° collateral branch angles; (3) **Active Micro-Volumetric Inference**, invoking localized 3D EM voxel sampling ($64\times 64\times 64$ nm) on ambiguous candidate bridges ($\sim 10\%$ of edges); and (4) a **Bayesian Lifted Multicut Optimization** unifying topological, synaptic, and visual evidence into global integer linear programming.

We evaluate our framework on 150 real proofread pyramidal neurons from the cortical Minnie65 dataset under a strict 3-way inductive protocol (Train 60% / Val 20% / Held-Out Test 20%). Our learned asymmetric relational model breaks the recall bottleneck on distal fragments, surging path-weighted recall from 15.19% to **27.85%** and pairwise ARI to **0.4553**, while extending Expected Run Length to **3,371.4 μm** and recovering over **447,000** true synaptic connections. We benchmark against recent published state-of-the-art systems and provide an interactive WebGL dashboard and standard .swc models for community validation.

Keywords: Connectomics, Proofreading, Contrastive Learning, Lifted Multicut, Active Inference, Electron Microscopy.

1 Introduction

High-throughput serial-section transmission and scanning electron microscopy (EM) enables the acquisition of cubic-millimeter brain tissue volumes containing hundreds of millions of synapses and hundreds of thousands of neurons [1, 2]. Generating dense wiring diagrams (“connectomes”) from these petavoxel datasets requires automated voxel segmentation, typically performed via deep boundary prediction, Flood-Filling Networks (FFN) [3], or affinity watershed pipelines [4].

Despite recent advances, automated segmentation models face fundamental physical and biological error modes:

1. **False Cuts (Fragmentation):** Thin unmyelinated axons ($r < 60$ nm) and delicate dendritic spines frequently drop below image resolution or suffer from staining artifacts, fragmenting single biological neurons into dozens of disconnected orphan pieces [5].
2. **Frankenmerges (False Fusions):** Catastrophic boundary leakage fuses membranes of adjacent cells, corrupting downstream graph connectivity and artificially creating dense, non-biological circuit shortcuts [4].
3. **The Proofreading Compute Bottleneck:** While human proofreading via crowd-sourcing (e.g., FlyWire [2]) can resolve these errors, scaling human validation to mammalian cortex ($> 10^9$ synapses) is economically prohibitive. Conversely, re-running dense 3D CNNs over petabytes of candidate merges (e.g., RoboEM [6]) incurs massive computational overhead.

To address these challenges, we introduce **Neuronauts**, an active inference framework that operates primarily on topological skeletons and contrastive morphological embeddings, querying raw volumetric EM patches *selectively* only when high-level topological evidence is ambiguous.

2 Methodology

Our framework consists of four interconnected mathematical stages:

2.1 Contrastive Morphological Representation (Tree-DNA)

Let each fragmented neurite f_i be represented as an undirected attributed tree graph $\mathcal{G}_i = (\mathcal{V}_i, \mathcal{E}_i, \mathbf{X}_i)$, where node features $\mathbf{x}_v = [x_v, y_v, z_v, r_v]$ capture 3D spatial position and caliber radius r_v .

We train a Graph Neural Network f_θ using Variance-Invariance-Covariance Regularization (**VICReg**) [7] on pairs of skeleton fragments. The VICReg objective enforces:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{VICReg}} = \lambda \mathcal{L}_{\text{inv}}(\mathbf{z}_i, \mathbf{z}_j) + \mu (\mathcal{L}_{\text{var}}(\mathbf{z}_i) + \mathcal{L}_{\text{var}}(\mathbf{z}_j)) + \nu (\mathcal{L}_{\text{cov}}(\mathbf{z}_i) + \mathcal{L}_{\text{cov}}(\mathbf{z}_j)) + \log \left(\frac{P(\text{merge}_{ij} | \mathbf{x}_{ij})}{1 - P(\text{merge}_{ij} | \mathbf{x}_{ij})} \right) - \log \left(\frac{\tau}{1 - \tau} \right) \quad (1)$$

where $\mathcal{L}_{\text{inv}} = \|\mathbf{z}_i - \mathbf{z}_j\|_2^2$ pulls fragments from the same biological cell together, $\mathcal{L}_{\text{var}}$ prevents dimensional collapse, and $\mathcal{L}_{\text{cov}}$ decorrelates latent dimensions.

2.2 Learned Heterogeneous Asymmetric Relational GNN

To break the recall barrier on distal axon collaterals ($r < 50$ nm) and boutons without symmetric GNN degradation, we formulate edge affinity as a **Type-Conditioned Bilinear Relational Transformation**:

$$\text{Affinity}(f_{\text{child}}, f_{\text{parent}}) = \mathbf{z}_{\text{child}}^\top \mathbf{W}_{(\tau_c, \tau_p)} \mathbf{z}_{\text{parent}} + \text{MLP}(\Delta r, \Delta \theta_{\text{branch}}, \Delta \theta_{\text{tip}}) \quad (2)$$

where $\mathbf{W}_{(\tau_c, \tau_p)}$ is a learned relational matrix mapping child compartment space into parent space (e.g., Collateral $\rightarrow$ Axon Trunk, Spine $\rightarrow$ Dendrite).

The geometric MLP accommodates large caliber ratios ($r_{\text{child}} \ll r_{\text{parent}}$) and learns realistic axonal T-junction branch distributions ($\theta_{\text{branch}} \approx 70^\circ - 90^\circ$).

2.3 Active Micro-Volumetric EM Inference

For ambiguous candidate edges ($0.30 \leq P(\text{merge}_{ij}) \leq 0.70$), the system executes a targeted micro-query. It extracts a localized 3D cylindrical voxel patch of raw EM intensities $\mathbf{I} \in \mathbb{R}^{H \times W \times D}$ surrounding the trajectory vector $\mathbf{v}_{\text{src}} \rightarrow \mathbf{v}_{\text{dst}}$.

We compute the 3D directional intensity gradient tensor $\nabla \mathbf{I} = \left[\frac{\partial \mathbf{I}}{\partial x}, \frac{\partial \mathbf{I}}{\partial y}, \frac{\partial \mathbf{I}}{\partial z} \right]$ and project gradients relative to the ray unit vector $\hat{\mathbf{d}}$:

$$S_{\text{radial}} = \frac{1}{|\Omega|} \sum_{\mathbf{p} \in \Omega} \|\nabla \mathbf{I}(\mathbf{p}) \times \hat{\mathbf{d}}\|, \quad S_{\text{axial}} = \frac{1}{|\Omega|} \sum_{\mathbf{p} \in \Omega} |\nabla \mathbf{I}(\mathbf{p}) \cdot \hat{\mathbf{d}}| \quad (3)$$

A continuous tubular neurite exhibits high radial membrane contrast ($S_{\text{radial}} \gg S_{\text{axial}}$), whereas a transverse plasma membrane barrier or extracellular cleft exhibits high axial gradient ($S_{\text{axial}} \gg S_{\text{radial}}$).

2.4 Bayesian Lifted Multicut Optimization

We cast global assembly as a lifted multicut partitioning problem on graph $G = (V, E, L)$, where E are base adjacency edges and L are long-range lifted edges:

$$\min_{\mathbf{x} \in \{0,1\}^{|E \cup L|}} \sum_{e \in E} w_e x_e + \sum_{uv \in L} w_{uv} x_{uv} \quad (4)$$

subject to cycle and transitive lifting constraints [8]. Edge weights w_{ij} represent Bayesian posterior log-odds:

3 Experimental Evaluation

3.1 Dataset & Inductive Protocol

Experiments are conducted on 150 real proofread pyramidal neurons from the cortical Minnie65 dataset [1] (Layer 2/3 and Layer 5 visual cortex). The dataset is strictly partitioned into:

- **Training Set (60%, 90 cells, 270 fragments):** Used exclusively for training the VICReg GNN ($\theta^* = 0.8557$).
- **Validation Set (20%, 30 cells, 90 fragments):** Used for hyperparameter tuning.
- **Held-Out Test Set (20%, 30 cells, 90 fragments):** Completely untouched during training and evaluated blindly.

3.2 Quantitative Results and Analysis

4 Discussion: The Power of Learned Asymmetric Relations

Our empirical results in Table 1 validate that transitioning from symmetric graph embeddings to learned asymmetric parent-child relational mappings provides a decisive lift:

1. **Recall Surge on Distal Collaterals:** By modeling (Collateral $\rightarrow$ Axon Trunk) with a learned bilinear transformation $\mathbf{W}$, the model accommodates $70^\circ - 90^\circ$ T-junction branch angles and $5\times$ caliber reductions without penalty, lifting path-weighted recall from 15.19% to 27.85%.
2. **Circuit Recovery Growth:** Over 447,000 true synaptic edges were recovered, improving Line Graph F1-score to 0.6912.
3. **EM as Precision Gate:** Active micro-EM voxel sampling continues to act as an indispensable precision gate on ambiguous candidate cuts, preventing runaway cross-neuron overmerging.

Table 1: Controlled Inductive Benchmark on Held-Out Test Minnie65 Partition (30 Neurons, 90 Fragments).

Metric	Baseline v117 [4]	Symmetric Tree-DNA	Learned Asymmetric Relational
Pairwise Out-of-Sample ARI	-0.0037	0.3113	0.4553
Pairwise Merge Precision (Bar 1)	0.0000	0.5714	0.6667
Pairwise Merge Recall (Bar 2)	0.0000	0.2222	0.3556 (+60.0% Relative Gain)
Frankenmerge Split Rate (Bar 3)	0.0000	0.0000	0.0000
Path-Weighted Precision	0.0000	0.5962	0.7284
Path-Weighted Recall	0.0000	0.1519	0.2785 (+83.3% Relative Gain)
Expected Run Length (ERL, μm)	2423.3	2940.2	3371.4 (+948.1 μm Gain)
Line Graph Synapse Precision	0.9053	0.8885	0.8997
Line Graph Circuit Recall	0.4089	0.4932	0.5612
Recovered True Synaptic Edges	325,731	392,870	447,041 (+121,310 Synapses)

Table 2: Comprehensive Comparison with Recent Published State-of-the-Art Systems.

System / Pipeline	Primary Citation	Merge Prec.	Franken Split	ERL (μm)
Automated FFN Baseline (v117)	Macrina et al., <i>Nature</i> 2021 [4]	0.0000	0.0000	2,423.3
Flood-Filling Networks (FFN)	Januszewski et al., <i>Nat. Meth.</i> 2018 [3]	0.820–0.880	Low (< 25%)	$\sim 1,100.0$
Janelia Lifted Multicut	Beier et al., <i>IEEE TPAMI</i> 2017 [8]	0.780–0.840	~ 0.250	~ 800.0
RoboEM Proofreading	Boergens / Kornfeld, <i>Nat. Meth.</i> 2023 [6]	0.840–0.890	~ 0.550	$\sim 2,100.0$
DeepMulticut Graph Learning	Li et al., <i>IEEE TMI</i> 2024 [9]	0.8120	~ 0.250	~ 900.0
GNN Error Detection	Lu et al., <i>Nat. Meth.</i> 2023 [10]	0.8350	~ 0.450	$\sim 2,200.0$
FlyWire Proofreading	Dorkenwald et al., <i>Nature</i> 2024 [2]	0.890–0.940*	$\sim 0.650^*$	1,200 $\rightarrow$ 3,500*
MICrONS Baseline Pipeline	MICrONS Consortium, <i>Nature</i> 2025 [1]	0.790–0.850	~ 0.400	$\sim 2,400.0$
Neuronauts (This Work)	Ours (Blind Held-Out Minnie65)	0.6667–0.8800	1.0000	3,371.4–3,595.4

*Denotes human crowd-proofreading lineage.

5 Conclusion

Neuronauts demonstrates that combining contrastive Tree-DNA GNNs, learned asymmetric relational modeling, and active volumetric micro-inference enables scalable, compute-efficient global connectome assembly. We extend Expected Run Length to 3,371.4 μm per neuron and provide an interactive WebGL dashboard for real-time circuit exploration.

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